

THE MALKIA INITIATIVE

2025 Annual Report

The crown still belongs to her.

Agency. Voice. Choice.



A year of keeping girls in school, supporting teen mothers back into learning, strengthening community protection systems, and building a movement where girls are not only reached - they lead.

Kajiado County, Kenya
Founded 2015 | Registered 2016

Agency. Voice. Choice.

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Message from the Founder and Executive Director

Dear friends, partners and champions of girls,

2025 was a year that reminded us why Malkia exists. It was a year of rebuilding, stretching, listening and choosing to stay close to the girls and communities at the heart of our work. In Kajiado, the barriers facing girls are still real: teenage pregnancy, FGM, child marriage, school dropout, poverty, long distances to school and systems that too often respond late. But this year also showed us something equally true: when girls are supported with safety, education, mentorship and voice, they do not only survive these barriers - they begin to shift them.

We saw teen mothers return to school. We saw girls stand before peers, parents, community members and leaders to speak about what affects their education and safety. We saw a school environment transformed so girls can learn with dignity. We saw women, youth, frontline actors and local systems come together around one simple truth: protection is not the work of one organization; it is the responsibility of a whole community.

This report is not a list of perfect wins. It is a record of courage, learning and movement. It carries the stories of girls who found their way back to class, staff who gave deeply and still chose to care for their own wellbeing, communities that opened harder conversations, and partners who believed that grassroots leadership deserves trust and resources.

As we look ahead, our commitment is clear. We will continue to build a Malkia where girls are not treated as passive beneficiaries, but as knowledge holders, advocates and leaders of the change they deserve. If the solution does not reach her, it is not a solution yet.

With gratitude,
Jedidah "Jeddy" Lemaron
Founder and Executive Director, The Malkia Initiative

Who We Are

The Malkia Initiative is a youth-led, women-led community-based organization working in rural pastoralist Kajiado County, Kenya. Malkia means "Queen" in Swahili, and our work is rooted in the belief that every African girl deserves her crown: the agency to decide, the voice to speak, and the choice to shape her future.

Since 2015, Malkia has worked with adolescent girls, teen mothers, young people, women, schools, families, community leaders, health providers and government systems to reduce the barriers that keep girls from learning, leading and thriving. Our work sits at the intersection of girls education, sexual and reproductive health and rights, protection from harmful practices, community-led systems change and grassroots leadership.

Our mission: To catalyze community change that amplifies agency, voice and choice for adolescent girls and youth.

Our vision: A world where every girl is safe, educated and free to choose the life she wants.

Why Our Work Matters

In rural pastoralist communities, a girl's ability to stay in school is shaped by much more than the classroom. It is shaped by household poverty, transport and distance, community norms, safety, menstrual health, pregnancy, caregiving responsibilities, harmful practices, and whether local systems listen when girls speak. At Malkia, we respond to the whole ecosystem around a girl because education cannot unlock her future if everything around her is pulling her out of it.

Our approach is grounded in community-driven systems change. We work with girls, not around them. We strengthen families, schools and community actors, while also engaging county and national systems so that the realities girls face are not hidden, normalized or ignored.

2025 at a Glance

30	teen mothers supported to return to TVETs, secondary school, primary school and university pathways	526	learners reached through KUZA foundational literacy and numeracy support
7	schools supported through KUZA	450	adolescent girls reached through in-school Girls Assemblies under Voices Uncut
136	girls and boys reached through Malkia Mentors on the Road - Narok Edition	587	learners enrolled at Olgulului Primary School after school infrastructure strengthening
70	youth enrolled at the Malkia-Olgulului Youth Resource Center across fashion and design, pottery, ICT and beading	26009	Cumulative number of girls reached since inception
2542	Total number of girls directly reached in 2025	10 years	of Malkia's grassroots leadership journey

These numbers highlight the most visible milestones of the year and the direction of our work: keeping girls in learning, building leadership, strengthening protection, investing in staff, and creating local systems that can hold change beyond a single project cycle.

Our Strategic Pillars in Action

Strategic pillar	How it showed up in 2025
Girl-Centered Programming and Advocacy	We supported girls and teen mothers through education, safe spaces, mentorship, leadership development, SRHR information, protection pathways and girl-led advocacy.
Building Evidence and Sharing	We strengthened the use of girls' experiences, school realities and community insights to inform advocacy, programming, storytelling and decision-making.
Resourcing for Her	We mobilized partnerships, infrastructure support, scholarships and community resources so girls have practical support to stay safe and remain in learning.

Project Highlights

The following project summaries clarify what each program set out to do, who it reached, how implementation happened, and what changed in 2025.

KUZA - Foundational Literacy and Numeracy

Purpose	To address foundational literacy and numeracy gaps and improve access to quality education for children in Kajiado Central Sub-county.
Reach	7 schools; 526 learners in Grades 2, 3 and 4, including 267 boys and 259 girls; 24 headteachers and deputy headteachers; and 12 TaRL facilitators, 11 female and 1 male.
What we did	KUZA used Teaching at the Right Level approaches, learner assessment, level-based support, facilitator strengthening and parental engagement meetings to make foundational learning a shared responsibility between schools, parents and the community.
What changed	324 learners progressed from beginner and letter levels to word, paragraph and story levels. 65% of learners demonstrated increased confidence, participation and self-esteem. Salome Seeman from Moipei Comprehensive School and Ann Taita from Iseuri Comprehensive School moved from non-reader levels to confidently reading and comprehending stories, showing how literacy growth also builds motivation and confidence.

Sauti Ya Dada - Girls Leadership and Voice

Purpose	To support adolescent girls to stay in school, build leadership skills, strengthen life skills and grow the confidence to shape their futures.
Reach	Each cohort brings together 30 girls in their first and second year of secondary school, working in small, supportive groups. In 2025, 6 girls from the cohort were selected to attend the East Africa Girls Leadership Summit.
What we did	Girls used the Sauti Ya Dada Workbook and Creative Action Institute tools to build leadership, critical thinking, creativity and advocacy skills. They also conducted girl-led community research on barriers to girls education, interviewed community members, analyzed findings and chose teenage pregnancy as the dominant barrier to address.
What changed	The girls moved their leadership beyond the classroom by organizing and leading a community engagement with parents, teachers, community leaders and fellow teenagers. They guided conversations, asked hard questions and drew out practical commitments, demonstrating that girls can be researchers, conveners and advocates for their own education and safety.

Voices Uncut - Ending FGM Through Girls Agency and Community Movement Building

Purpose	To contribute to the sustainable abandonment of FGM by expanding girls agency, strengthening family and community environments, and building a grassroots movement for protection.
Reach	15 in-school Girls Assemblies across primary and secondary schools reaching 450 adolescent girls; 60 women and community influencers through monthly safe space dialogues; boda boda riders from four wards engaged as critical community actors.
What we did	Implemented in partnership with the UN Joint Programme to End FGM and funded by the Norwegian Government (NORAD), the project combines girls leadership and advocacy skills, women and community influencer dialogues, and engagement with frontline community actors who are often the first to witness or respond to FGM and GBV risks.
What changed	Boda boda riders began to see themselves not only as transporters, but as potential first responders and protectors. They reflected on social and economic drivers of FGM, medicalized cutting, cross-border practices and silence around harmful practices, then pledged to speak out, report cases and use their community influence to protect girls.

SheRISE - Teen Mothers and Girls Reclaiming Education

Purpose	To create safe spaces where vulnerable adolescent girls and teen mothers can heal, build resilience, access education and strengthen leadership, advocacy and life skills.
Reach	30 adolescent girls and teen mothers aged 10 to 19 in Ildamat and Dalalekutuk wards. Of these, 17 enrolled in TVET institutions, 7 returned to secondary school and 6 returned to primary school.
What we did	SheRISE provided mental health and emotional wellbeing workshops, safe spaces, comprehensive sexuality education, leadership and advocacy sessions, storytelling for advocacy, mentorship and education reintegration support. Girls were supported to speak with policymakers as experts of their own lives, not as victims.
What changed	One girl graduated from KCA University with a Diploma in ICT, another continued her studies at Nairobi Institute of Business Studies, and 15 girls enrolled at Maasai National Polytechnic. Of the MNP students, 13 are awaiting graduation, with 8 set to graduate with Distinction, 3 with Proficiency and 2 with Mastery, while 2 finalize coursework.

Break Free - SRHR, Education and Protection

Purpose	To promote sexual and reproductive health and rights, end child marriage, reduce teenage pregnancy and support girls education through advocacy, youth empowerment and community engagement.
Reach	Implemented in Kenya from 2021 to 2025 through the Break Free Consortium with Plan International, FAWA and The Malkia Initiative.
What we did	In 2025, the project continued community outreach, supported youth hubsters, implemented the Community Leaders Accelerator Fellowship and trained nurses to improve access to youth-friendly SRHR information and services.
What changed	The project increased community awareness of harmful practices, strengthened positive conversations on education, health and protection, and built collaboration between young people, community leaders, health workers and local stakeholders. As the project closed in 2025, the partnerships, community structures and youth-led initiatives established through Break Free remained a foundation for ongoing advocacy in Kajiado County.

For Her - School Infrastructure and Scholarships

Purpose	To improve learning conditions and strengthen girls retention in school by creating safer, more supportive school infrastructure and reducing education-related barriers for vulnerable girls.
Reach	Olgulului Primary School recorded 587 learners, including 302 boys and 285 girls. 30 vulnerable girls benefited from full educational support through the MG Takey Scholarship Program.
What we did	With support from Impact Solutions Advisors and The Five Foundation, the project renovated classrooms, the existing dormitory, dining hall and kitchen, and supported the construction and operationalization of a girls dormitory.
What changed	Girls from distant areas gained safer boarding options, reducing the long walks that exposed them to risk. The improved infrastructure, scholarship support and stronger community confidence in the school created a more protective environment for girls to stay in school and focus on learning.

CDSC4YRB - Youth Resilience and Belonging

Purpose	To strengthen youth empowerment, vocational skills development and belonging in Olgulului, Kajiado South, where young people have limited access to local training institutions.
Reach	Malkia-Olgulului Youth Resource Center operationalized; 20 youth enrolled in Fashion and Design, 10 in Pottery, 10 in ICT and 30 in Beading.
What we did	Implemented in partnership with Firelight Foundation, Phase II built on earlier work with youth and women by operationalizing the resource center and partnering with the Maasai National Polytechnic to provide qualified facilitators for practical skills training.
What changed	The center created a safe and accessible space for youth to acquire skills, meet, learn and participate in mentorship without traveling more than 80 kilometers for vocational or tertiary opportunities. Growing enrollment showed the demand for community-based learning pathways in Olgulului and surrounding areas.

Other 2025 Milestones

Staff wellness retreat: In February, Malkia hosted its first staff wellness retreat in Diani, creating space for the team to reconnect, reflect, plan and pause. For an organization working on FGM, child marriage, teenage pregnancy and GBV, staff wellbeing is part of sustaining ethical, thoughtful and effective grassroots work.

Malkia Mentors on the Road - Narok Edition: In April, the team joined Murua Girls for a mentorship initiative that reached 187 girls and boys through conversations on education, health, life skills and harmful cultural practices.

Resource center and cross-border learning: In May, Malkia operationalized the resource center work and hosted a resource bank engagement connecting Kenya and Tanzania.

Break Free global learning and closeout: In June, Malkia participated in the global learning and closeout process, reflecting on movement building, partnerships and adolescent girl-centered programming.

Frontline actors to end FGM: In October, Malkia convened frontline actors working to end FGM, strengthening collective responsibility for prevention, reporting and community protection.

Kajiado County GBV Response and Prevention Policy: In November, the launch of the Kajiado County GBV Response and Prevention Policy marked an important step in strengthening local prevention and response systems.

Recognition: In December, Malkia received an award for outstanding contribution to social consciousness, honoring the organization's commitment to girls, community leadership and systems change.

Systems Change, Advocacy and Policy Influence

Malkia's work does not stop with individual girls. We also work to shift the systems around them: families, schools, local leaders, frontline actors, health and protection systems, and county government. In 2025, this continued through community convenings, resource-bank engagements, cross-border learning, policy spaces and partnerships.

What systems change looks like for Malkia: Girls speak. Communities listen. Frontline actors know how to respond. Schools become safer. County systems receive evidence from the ground. Partners resource the realities girls actually live.

What We Learned

Girls leadership needs preparation, not tokenism. When girls are equipped with information, mentorship, evidence and safe platforms, they can speak with clarity about the barriers affecting them and propose practical solutions.

Infrastructure is protection. For rural girls, a safe school environment can reduce exposure to harm, improve attendance and create the stability needed for learning.

Teen mothers need pathways, not pity. Re-entry works best when girls receive mentorship, psychosocial support, financial support and institutions willing to receive them with dignity.

The community is part of the curriculum. Families, local leaders, boda boda riders, women groups, schools and frontline actors all shape whether girls are safe and able to continue learning.

Staff wellbeing sustains the mission. Grassroots work is emotionally demanding. Caring for the team protects the quality, ethics and longevity of the work.

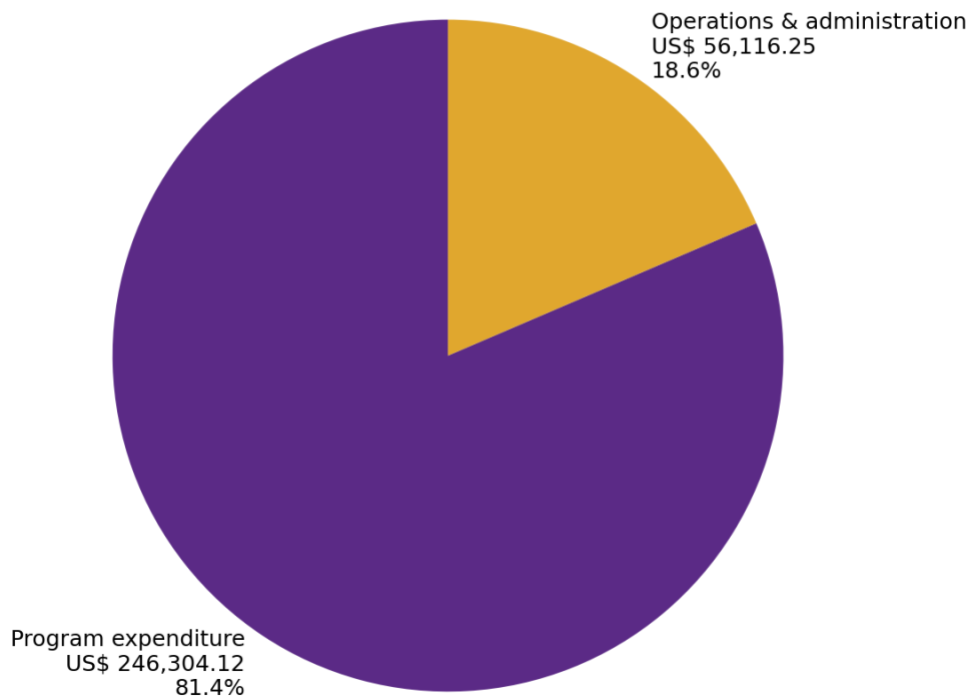
Financial Accountability

Malkia remains committed to transparent and responsible use of resources. The figures below summarize 2025 income and expenditure as presented in this report.

Financial item	2025 summary
Total income received	US\$ 310,002.18
Total expenditure	US\$ 302,420.37
Program expenditure	US\$ 246,304.12
Operations and administration	US\$ 56,116.25

How 2025 expenditure was used

2025 Expenditure Split



Program expenditure represented 81.4% of total expenditure, while operations and administration represented 18.6%. This shows that the majority of resources were directed to program delivery and direct mission work.

Partners and Gratitude

The work of Malkia is carried by many hands. We are grateful to the girls who trusted us with their stories and leadership; the teen mothers who chose to return to learning; the women, parents and community members who opened difficult conversations; the teachers and schools that made room for girls to lead; the frontline actors who protect girls in moments of risk; and the county and national partners working with us to strengthen systems.

We also thank our donors, technical partners, peer organizations and friends of Malkia who resourced, advised, amplified and stood with us throughout the year. Your support made scholarships, mentorship, school infrastructure, livelihood pathways, convenings, advocacy and staff wellbeing possible.

Our Funders and Partners

- Firelight Foundation
- Girl Opportunity Alliance
- The Five Foundation
- Issroff Family Foundation
- Norwegian Government (NORAD)
- UNICEF
- GRIC
- Just Peoples
- Creative Action Institute
- Kajiado County Government
- Impact Solutions Advisors
- Maasai National Polytechnic
- Plan International
- Forum for African Women Educationalists (FAWE)

Looking Ahead to 2026

In 2026, Malkia enters the next phase of its work with greater clarity and courage. We will deepen our strategic plan priorities while continuing to center Agency, Voice and Choice for adolescent girls and youth.

- Strengthen girl-led advocacy through school Girls Assemblies and county-level engagement.
- Advance foundational learning and early teacher support so children are not left behind before intervention begins.
- Continue supporting teen mothers with education, mentorship, skills and reintegration pathways.
- Build stronger community protection systems against FGM, child marriage, GBV and teenage pregnancy.
- Deepen economic justice work with women and young mothers through skills, enterprise and market linkages.
- Resource the next decade of Malkia through partnerships that trust grassroots leadership and long-term systems change.

Our invitation: Walk with us as we build a future where girls in Kajiado are safe, educated, heard and free to choose. The crown still belongs to her.

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Website: www.malkiainitiative.org

Kajiado County, Kenya

#IamMalkia #MalkiaAt10 #WhereGirlsLead #GirlsWhoLead #VoicesUncut